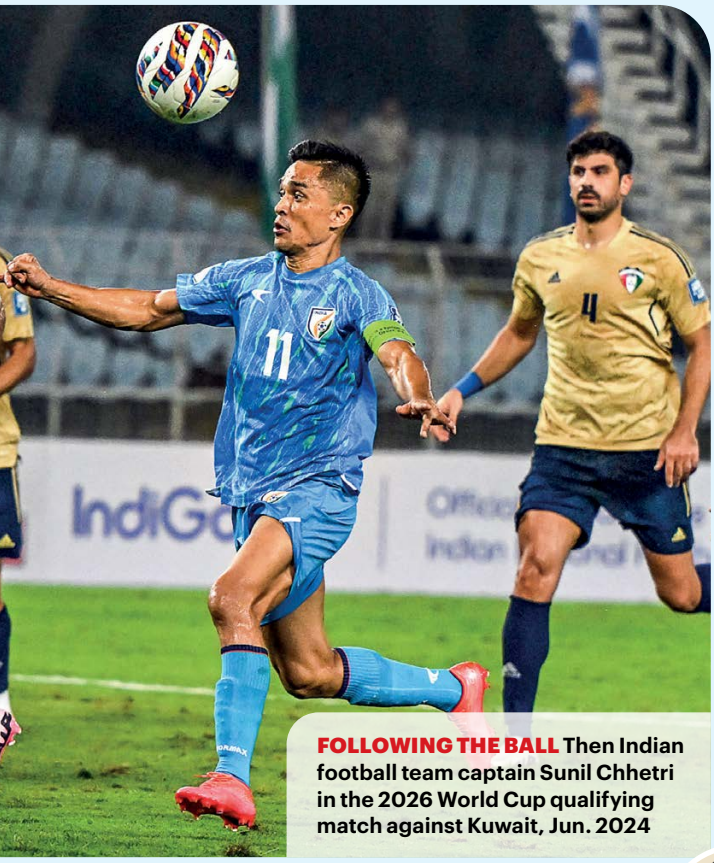


FOLLOWING THE BALL Then Indian football team captain Sunil Chhetri in the 2026 World Cup qualifying match against Kuwait, Jun. 2024

...HOW WE CAN RISE

The steps needed to make Indian football a force to reckon with

- **Talent identification needs to be systematic through experienced scouts to have a pool of gen next footballers**
- **Development of youngsters through residential football schools combining education with elite coaching**
- **Better financial guarantees so as to encourage youth to take up the sport as career**
- **AIFF must resolve its disputes and offer clear guidelines, emphasise long-term planning**
- **More competitive matches in a stable domestic league**
- **Provision for footballers amongst the diaspora to represent the country**
- **Regular qualification at the AFC Asian Cup should be first goal. World Cup qualification will follow naturally**
- **Resolution of club-versus-country conflicts**

A BROKEN SYSTEM

If India's talent pipeline is weak, its apex football institutions have been no less fragile. The AIFF has spent the past few years in legal disputes and disagreements with stakeholders. The prolonged uncertainty over the ISL in 2025-26 was the epitome of that dysfunction. With the commercial agreement governing the country's premier competition expiring and no resolution in sight, players publicly appealed for the league to continue. The possibility of India's top-tier tournament not taking place exposed how vulnerable the domestic calendar was. Running a professional football club in India costs an estimated Rs 60 crore annually. Without a stable competition calendar, clubs struggle to retain sponsors and ticket revenues plummet.

The fractured relationship between the AIFF and state football associations has adversely affected development. It was most evident when Mohun Bagan refused to release seven players for national duty in the Unity Cup—a tournament in London featuring Jamaica, Nigeria, Zimbabwe and India—as it is not part of FIFA's international window and also due to valid injury concerns, since AIFF doesn't take financial responsibility for injured players in training camps.



"THERE IS A SHORTAGE OF FOOTBALL GROUNDS FOR KIDS. NOT JUST ACADEMIES, YOU NEED TO HAVE LEAGUES THAT RUN ALL YEAR ROUND FOR YOUNG PLAYERS"

PRADHYUM REDDY, *Former head coach, Shillong Lajong FC*

Inevitably, administrative uncertainty has affected onfield performance. Croatian Igor Štimac's five-year tenure (2019-2024) as India's head coach produced mixed results. He guided India to three titles in 2023—the SAFF Championship, the Tri-Nation Series and the Intercontinental Cup—and briefly restored India's ranking to the FIFA top 100. But Štimac was dismissed in June 2024 after India crashed out of the 2023 AFC Asian Cup without a point and after the disappointment of the 2026 FIFA World Cup qualifiers. When Khalid Jamil took over in August 2025, some within the AIFF believed he should initially have been appointed on a short-term basis. His two-year contract renewed the debate over the need for appointments to be guided by long-term strategy.

Former AIFF president Praful Patel rejects the suggestion that Indian football lacks direction. While acknowledging the shortcomings of his administration (2009-2022), he insists that there was a long-term vision. "Our plan was to qualify for the World Cup by 2030. So we were taking one step at a time and things were improving," he says.

But even if India succeeds in identifying better talent and fixing its administration, one question remains: is football an attractive profession? For